

PARKER BECK

The Parker Beck Cookbook

Recipes and menus from 2025 and 2026

Birthday dinners, Jorts and Forks menus,
weeknight meals and ideas worth cooking again.

A personal collection for cooking at home and hosting friends. The menus bring the dishes together; the recipe pages give quantities, methods, variations and preparation notes.

September 2026 edition

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Using the recipes

Ingredients are grouped for quick shopping. Read the method before starting and check the cooking notes for temperatures and seafood handling. Scale recipes to the number of guests; a full tasting menu needs smaller portions than a standalone dinner.

The birthday menus

Two celebrations from August and September 2026

Kelli 30th Birthday Celebration

Final menu • September 25 2026

Appetizers. Fig and blue cheese tart with sautéed onions and hot honey; otoro crispy rice with spicy aioli, avocado, scallions and toasted sesame; caviar spread with sea salt and vinegar chips, potatoes pavé, toasted sourdough, French butter and accoutrements; mini lobster rolls with caviar, chives and edible 24k gold flake.

Main course. Steak au poivre with roasted fennel, asparagus and freshly shaved truffle.

Dessert. Mint chocolate chip ice cream with chocolate brownie chunks and cookie dough bites.

Drinks. Dirty martini with blue cheese olives; Sauvignon Blanc.

Parker 31st Birthday Dinner

Final menu • August 17 2026

Small bite starters. Steak frites bites; salmon crudo with chives, jalapeño, spicy mayo and miso sauce; tuna tartare with avocado, jalapeño, sesame, pickled radish and fried shallots in a wonton cone.

For the table. Charcuterie with assorted cheeses, fresh figs, candied nuts, olives, Italian meats and gherkins; elote dip; Swiss and Gruyère fondue with toasted baguette.

Main entrée. Duck breast with fig sauce, roasted rainbow carrots, roasted fennel and small crispy potatoes.

The Jorts and Forks menus

New England comfort and a spring steakhouse dinner

Jorts and Forks

October 22 2025

Starters. Truffle pesto crostini; Rhode Island style stuffies with clams, chorizo, breadcrumbs, herbs and lemon butter.

Main. Wagyu au poivre with shiitake mushrooms, roasted garlic mashed potatoes and buttered asparagus.

Dessert. Espresso martini crème brûlée.

Drinks. Dirty martini with blue cheese olives; mudslide.

Jorts and Forks Spring Steakhouse Edition

April 24 2026 • Menu planned for 4 to 5

To start. Whipped ricotta crostini with roasted tomato, lemon, honey and basil; chilled pea and mint soup shots with crème fraîche and pistachios.

Main. Reverse-seared steak with garlic herb butter and raspberry balsamic sauce; truffle Parmesan smashed potatoes; charred asparagus with lemon Caesar dressing and breadcrumbs.

Dessert. Midnight Snack strawberry shortcake sundaes with vanilla ice cream or whipped mascarpone, berries and shortbread or pound cake.

Make the butter, sauce, soup and berries ahead. Finish steak, potatoes and asparagus just before serving.

Seasonal dinner menus

Two menus built around fruit and a savory main

Fig and branzino dinner

September 3 2026

Starter. Heirloom tomato and fresh fig tart with whipped feta, shallot, thyme, lemon zest and hot honey. The earlier version used tomatoes alone.

Main. Fig leaf wrapped branzino with lemon, thyme and garlic, finished with lemon herb beurre blanc.

Sides. Crispy pancetta fingerling potatoes; charred asparagus with Parmesan and lemon.

Optional salad. Shaved fennel and arugula with lemon vinaigrette and Parmesan.

Dessert and wine. Honeyed figs and mascarpone with pistachios; Vermentino di Gallura.

Venison dinner

January 30 2026

Main. Venison tenderloin with raspberry balsamic reduction.

Sides. Truffle Parmesan fries, lemon asparagus and whipped carrot purée.

Creamy Parmesan orzo was another side idea from the same planning conversation. Serve a small portion if adding it to the full menu.

More menus from the collection

Summer entertaining and Korean inspired duck

Summer dinner plan

July 17 2025

Starters. Marinated cherry tomatoes with ricotta and baguette; pesto, portobello, arugula, mozzarella and prosciutto tart.

Main and sides. Steak à la Parker; bacon herb potato salad; grilled asparagus; street corn casserole.

Dessert. Pound cake with grilled peaches, bourbon caramel and vanilla ice cream or whipped cream.

Korean barbecue duck dinner

November 4 2025

Starter. Soft-shell crab sandwich.

Main. KBBQ-marinated duck breast over whipped butternut squash, with duck-fat potatoes topped with melted raclette.

Banchan ideas. White pear and daikon kimchi; charred scallion sesame spinach; honey gochugaru lotus root; cucumber oi muchim; lettuce or perilla wraps with ssamjang and rice; miso-roasted eggplant.

Choose two small vegetable sides for a manageable dinner.

Fig and blue cheese tart

Kelli birthday menu • September 2026

Makes 6 appetizer portions • 20 minutes prep • 35 minutes cooking

Ingredients. 1 thawed puff pastry sheet; 6 fresh figs, quartered; 1 medium onion, thinly sliced; 1 tbsp butter; 1 tsp olive oil; 3 oz blue cheese, crumbled; 1 egg, beaten; 1–2 tbsp hot honey; black pepper; 1 tsp thyme leaves, optional.

1. Heat the oven to 400°F. Line a sheet pan with parchment. Cook the onion in butter and olive oil over medium-low heat for 15–20 minutes, stirring, until soft and lightly golden. Cool briefly.
2. Unfold the pastry onto the pan. Score a ½-inch border without cutting through. Prick the center with a fork and brush the border with egg.
3. Spread the onions inside the border. Scatter over the blue cheese and arrange the figs cut-side up. Add pepper and optional thyme.
4. Bake for 22–28 minutes until the pastry is deeply golden underneath and the figs are softened. Rest for 5 minutes, drizzle with hot honey and cut into small rectangles.

Prep ahead: cook and refrigerate the onions up to 2 days ahead. Assemble close to baking so the pastry stays crisp. Serve small pieces before the richer seafood courses.

Two savory tarts

Fig and branzino dinner • Summer dinner plan

Heirloom tomato and fresh fig tart

Serves 4 as a starter • About 45 minutes

Ingredients. 1 puff pastry sheet; 4 oz feta; 2 tbsp Greek yogurt; 2 medium heirloom tomatoes; 2–3 figs; 1 small shallot, sliced; 1 tsp thyme; ½ tsp lemon zest; 1 tbsp hot honey; 1 egg; olive oil.

1. Heat the oven to 400°F. Slice tomatoes, lightly salt and drain on towels for 15 minutes. Blend feta with yogurt. Score a border on pastry, prick the middle and brush the edge with beaten egg.
2. Spread feta in the center. Top with tomatoes and figs in roughly a 70:30 ratio, then shallot and thyme. Drizzle with a little oil. Bake 25–30 minutes until golden; finish with zest and hot honey.

Earlier variation: omit figs, add caramelized onion and finish with chopped pistachios.

Pesto portobello and prosciutto tart

Serves 4 as a starter • About 40 minutes

Ingredients. 1 puff pastry sheet; 2 portobello caps, sliced; 1 tbsp olive oil; 3 tbsp pesto; 4 oz well-drained fresh mozzarella; 2 oz prosciutto; 1 cup arugula; 1 beaten egg.

1. Sauté mushrooms in oil until browned and dry. Cool. Prepare pastry with a scored border and egg-washed edge. Spread pesto inside, then add mushrooms and torn mozzarella.
2. Bake at 400°F for 25–30 minutes until the bottom is crisp. Add prosciutto and arugula after baking. Cut into squares and serve warm.

Crostini and burrata

Summer 2025 • Jorts and Forks 2025 and 2026

Whipped ricotta and roasted tomato crostini

Makes 12 • About 30 minutes

Ingredients. 12 baguette slices; 1 cup ricotta; 1 pint cherry tomatoes; 2 tbsp olive oil, divided; 1 tsp lemon zest; 2 tsp honey; 6 basil leaves; salt and pepper.

1. Roast tomatoes with 1 tbsp oil and a pinch of salt at 400°F for 20 minutes. Brush bread with remaining oil; toast on a separate tray for the final 7–9 minutes.
2. Whip ricotta with lemon zest and a pinch of salt. Spread on toast; add tomatoes, honey, torn basil and pepper.

Summer variation: marinate halved raw tomatoes in oil, salt and basil for 20 minutes, then spoon over ricotta. Keep the ricotta chilled until serving.

Truffle pesto crostini

Makes 12 • 15 minutes

Ingredients. 12 baguette slices; 1 tbsp olive oil; 3 tbsp truffle pesto; ¼ cup shaved Parmesan; flaky salt.

1. Brush bread with oil and toast at 400°F for 7–9 minutes. Spread a thin layer of pesto on each warm slice; finish with Parmesan and a small pinch of salt.

Black truffle burrata with hot honey

Serves 2 to 4 • 15 minutes

Ingredients. 1 ball black truffle burrata, about 4 oz; 1 small candy cane beet, peeled; 2 radishes; 1 tbsp olive oil; 1–2 tsp hot honey; lemon juice; salt.

1. Shave beet and radishes very thinly. Toss with oil, a squeeze of lemon and a pinch of salt. Place around burrata and drizzle with hot honey. Serve with toast.

Menu names from the original discussion included Truffle Shuffle and The Truffle Bloom.

The caviar spread

Kelli birthday menu • September 2026

Caviar with French butter and sourdough

Serves 2 generously as part of several appetizers • 20 minutes

Ingredients. 30–50 g caviar; 4 small sourdough slices; 2–3 tbsp French butter; a small bowl of sea salt and vinegar chips; 6–8 cooked potato pavé bites; ¼ cup crème fraîche; 1 tbsp chopped chives; 1 hard-boiled egg, finely chopped; 1 tbsp finely minced shallot, rinsed and dried; lemon wedges, optional.

1. Toast sourdough lightly and cut into small pieces. Let it cool to warm so it does not melt the caviar garnish.
2. Place the caviar tin in a shallow bowl over ice, keeping meltwater out. Put butter, crème fraîche, egg, shallot and chives in separate small dishes.
3. Arrange bread, chips and warm potato bites around the chilled toppings. Let each person build a bite. Use small amounts of the sharper accompaniments so the caviar remains prominent.

Prep ahead: chop the cooked egg, shallot and chives the day before and refrigerate separately. Open the caviar at service and follow its label for storage.

Potato chip caviar bites

For 12 bites, use 12 sturdy chips, ¼ cup crème fraîche, 20–30 g caviar and 1 tsp chives. Add a small dab of cream to each chip, then caviar and chives. Assemble immediately before eating so the chips stay crisp.

Classic blinis

For 12 bites, warm 12 small blinis as directed on the package. Mix ¼ cup crème fraîche with 1 tsp chives and a tiny pinch of lemon zest. Let the blinis cool to just warm, then top with cream and 20–30 g caviar.

Four more caviar appetizers

September 21 2026 • Each makes about 12 bites

Crispy smashed potatoes

About 55 minutes

Ingredients. 12 baby gold potatoes; 2 tbsp olive oil; ¼ cup crème fraîche; 20–30 g caviar; 1 tbsp chives; salt.

1. Boil potatoes in salted water for 12–18 minutes until tender. Drain and steam-dry 5 minutes. Flatten gently on an oiled tray.
2. Brush with oil; roast at 450°F for 25–30 minutes until crisp. Cool slightly, then add crème fraîche, caviar and chives.

Brown butter brioche with soft eggs

About 20 minutes

Ingredients. 3 brioche slices, quartered; 2 tbsp butter; 3 eggs; 1 tbsp crème fraîche; 20–30 g caviar; chives.

1. Brown 1 tbsp butter; brush onto bread. Toast at 375°F for 6–8 minutes.
2. Melt remaining butter on low heat. Add beaten eggs and stir gently until set; fold in crème fraîche. Spoon onto toast, then add caviar and chives. Use pasteurized eggs if serving a softer set.

Caviar deviled eggs

About 25 minutes plus chilling

Ingredients. 6 eggs; 2 tbsp mayonnaise; 1 tbsp crème fraîche; ¼ tsp Dijon; 1 tsp chives; 20–30 g caviar.

1. Hard-boil eggs, about 11 minutes, then chill in ice water. Peel and halve. Mash yolks with mayonnaise, crème fraîche, Dijon and chives. Fill whites, chill, and top with caviar at service.

Cucumber rounds with smoked salmon

15 minutes

Ingredients. 12 cucumber rounds, ⅓ inch thick; 2–3 oz smoked salmon; 3 tbsp crème fraîche; 20–30 g caviar; dill.

1. Pat cucumber dry. Add crème fraîche, a folded ribbon of smoked salmon, caviar and a tiny dill frond. Keep chilled until serving.

Potatoes pave

Birthday menus • August and September 2026

Makes about 16 small bites • 30 minutes prep • 75–100 minutes baking • Overnight chilling

Ingredients. 2 lb Yukon Gold potatoes; $\frac{3}{4}$ cup heavy cream; 4 tbsp butter, melted, plus butter for the pan; $\frac{3}{4}$ tsp fine salt; $\frac{1}{4}$ tsp pepper; neutral oil for frying. To finish: $\frac{1}{4}$ cup crème fraîche, 20–30 g caviar and chopped chives, optional.

1. Heat oven to 325°F. Butter an 8½-by-4½-inch loaf pan and line it with parchment, leaving an overhang. Mix cream, melted butter, salt and pepper in a large bowl.
2. Peel potatoes. Using a mandoline with its hand guard, slice about 1/16 inch thick directly into the cream. Toss gently; do not rinse away the starch.
3. Layer slices tightly in the pan, pressing down and alternating their direction. Add enough of the cream mixture to moisten the layers without flooding the top. Cover with parchment and foil.
4. Bake for 75–100 minutes, until a thin knife passes through without resistance. Let steam escape for 15–20 minutes. Cover with parchment, press with a second loaf pan and a light weight, and refrigerate promptly overnight.
5. Lift out, trim the edges and cut into 16 rectangles. Pat the cut surfaces dry. Shallow-fry in $\frac{1}{4}$ inch of oil over medium-high heat, turning, until golden and hot throughout. Drain on a rack.
6. Serve as a side or let the bites cool slightly before topping with crème fraîche, caviar and chives. Keep the caviar cold until the final moment.

The overnight press gives clean layers and sturdy pieces. Bake 1–2 days ahead; fry just before serving. If reheating chilled potatoes, heat through to 165°F.

Otoro crispy rice

Kelli birthday menu • Final fish upgrade September 25 2026

Makes 8–10 bites • 30 minutes active • At least 2 hours chilling

Ingredients. $\frac{3}{4}$ cup dry sushi rice; water per rice package; 1 tbsp rice vinegar; 1 tsp sugar; $\frac{1}{4}$ tsp salt; 4–5 oz otoro tuna intended for raw service; $\frac{1}{2}$ avocado, sliced; 2 tbsp mayonnaise; 1–2 tsp sriracha; $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp lime juice; 1 scallion, sliced; 1 tsp toasted sesame seeds; neutral oil for frying.

1. Rinse rice and cook according to the package. Dissolve sugar and salt in vinegar and gently fold into the cooked rice.
2. Press rice into a parchment-lined small dish in a $\frac{1}{2}$ -inch layer. Refrigerate promptly, loosely covered until cooled, then cover fully. Chill until firm, at least 2 hours or overnight.
3. Mix mayonnaise, sriracha and lime juice. Keep chilled. Slice otoro just before assembly and keep it over ice in a covered bowl while frying rice.
4. Cut rice into 8–10 rectangles. Shallow-fry in $\frac{1}{4}$ inch of oil over medium-high heat for about 3 minutes per side until golden. Drain; let cool to warm.
5. Top each piece with a little spicy aioli, avocado and otoro. Finish with scallions and toasted sesame. Serve immediately.

Use the raw seafood guidance in the cooking notes. The original menu moved from spicy tuna to chutoro and finally otoro; this version keeps the final selection. The rice and aioli can be prepared the day before.

Salmon crudo and tuna tartare

Parker birthday menu • August 2026

Salmon crudo with miso ponzu

Serves 4 as a small starter • 20 minutes

Ingredients. 8–12 oz salmon intended for raw service; 1 tbsp white miso; 1½ tbsp ponzu; 1 tbsp lime or yuzu juice; 1 tsp sesame oil; 1 tsp honey; ½ tsp rice vinegar; ½ tsp grated ginger; 1–2 tsp water; 2 tbsp mayo mixed with 1 tsp sriracha; thin jalapeño slices; chopped chives.

1. Whisk miso, ponzu, citrus, sesame oil, honey, vinegar, ginger and water until smooth. Chill.
2. Slice salmon thinly and arrange on chilled plates. Spoon the miso sauce around it immediately before serving. Add small dots of spicy mayo, jalapeño and chives. Do not marinate it for a long time.

Tuna tartare in wonton cones

Makes 12 small cones • About 30 minutes

Ingredients. 8 oz tuna intended for raw service, diced; ½ avocado, diced; 1 tbsp finely diced pickled radish; 1 tsp minced jalapeño; 1 tsp soy sauce; ½ tsp sesame oil; 1 tsp lime juice; 1 tsp toasted sesame; 2 tbsp fried shallots; 12 wonton wrappers; neutral oil.

1. Brush wrappers lightly with oil. Wrap around oven-safe metal cone molds, seal overlapping corners with a little water, and bake at 375°F for 8–12 minutes until golden. Cool and remove molds.
2. Just before serving, combine tuna, avocado, radish, jalapeño, soy, sesame oil and lime. Fill cones and top with sesame and fried shallots.

Alternative from the original notes: fry flat wonton wrappers and serve as crisps. Both dishes use raw seafood; see the cooking notes.

Lobster rolls and steak bites

Two celebration appetizers

Mini lobster rolls with caviar

Makes 4 mini rolls • 20 minutes

Ingredients. 6 oz cooked lobster meat, chopped; 3 tbsp butter, divided; 4 mini brioche rolls; 1 tsp lemon juice; 1 tbsp chives; 15–20 g caviar; a tiny amount of edible food-grade 24k gold leaf, optional.

1. Melt 1 tbsp butter and toast the split brioche rolls cut-side down. Keep warm.
2. Gently warm lobster in remaining butter just until heated. Fold in lemon and half the chives. Avoid boiling, which toughens lobster.
3. Fill rolls. Let the lobster cool to warm, then finish with chilled caviar, remaining chives and optional edible gold. Serve at once.

Steak frites bites with horseradish aioli

Makes 12 • About 35 minutes

Ingredients. 12 oz strip steak; 8 oz frozen shoestring fries; 1 tsp neutral oil; 12 long chives; 3 tbsp mayonnaise; 1–2 tsp prepared horseradish; ½ tsp lemon juice; salt and pepper.

1. Cook fries until crisp according to the package. Mix mayo, horseradish and lemon. Season steak; sear in a hot oiled pan, then finish as needed to 145°F and rest at least 3 minutes.
2. Briefly dip chives in hot water to soften, then cool and dry. Slice steak thinly across the grain. Wrap each slice around a small bundle of fries and tie gently with a chive.
3. Place on a platter and add a small dot of aioli to each. Assemble just before serving so the fries stay crisp.

For the middle of the table

August birthday planning • July summer entertaining

Elote dip

Serves 6 • About 25 minutes

Ingredients. 3 cups corn kernels; 1 tbsp oil; ¼ cup mayonnaise; ¼ cup Mexican crema or sour cream; ½ cup Cotija; 1 jalapeño, minced; 2 scallions, sliced; ¼ cup cilantro; juice of 1 lime; ½ tsp smoked paprika; ½ tsp Tajín; 1–2 tsp hot honey; tortilla chips.

1. Char corn in oil in a wide hot skillet, working in batches if needed. Let it cool slightly.
2. Mix with mayonnaise, crema, most of the cheese, jalapeño, scallions, cilantro and lime. Season with paprika and Tajín. Finish with remaining cheese and hot honey. Serve warm with chips.

Grilled peaches with burrata

Serves 4 • 20 minutes

Ingredients. 2 ripe but firm peaches, halved; 2 tsp oil; 8 oz burrata; 2 oz prosciutto; 2 tbsp pistachios; basil; 1 tbsp hot honey.

1. Brush peaches with oil and grill cut-side down over medium-high heat for 3–4 minutes. Slice and arrange around torn burrata.
2. Add prosciutto, pistachios and basil. Drizzle with hot honey and serve immediately.

Birthday charcuterie board

For 4–6 people sharing other starters, arrange 8–12 oz assorted cheeses, 6 oz Italian cured meats, 4 quartered figs, ½ cup olives, ½ cup gherkins, ¼ cup candied nuts and crackers or sliced bread. Keep wet accompaniments in small bowls. Put out a small portion of perishables and replenish from the refrigerator.

Fondue three ways

August 2026 • Serve over low heat

Swiss and Gruyere birthday fondue

Serves 4 to 6 as an appetizer • 25 minutes

Ingredients. 8 oz Gruyère; 8 oz Swiss cheese such as Emmental; 1 tbsp cornstarch; 1 garlic clove, halved; $\frac{3}{4}$ cup dry white wine, plus more to thin; 1 tsp lemon juice; 1 tsp Dijon; black pepper; 1 baguette, cubed and toasted.

1. Grate cheeses and toss with cornstarch. Rub the inside of a saucepan with the cut garlic.
2. Bring wine and lemon juice to a gentle simmer. Add cheese by handfuls, stirring until each addition melts before adding the next. Keep the heat low.
3. Stir in Dijon and pepper. Thin with a little warm wine if needed. Transfer to a fondue pot over gentle heat and serve with bread.

Gruyere and Fontina summer fondue

Use 8 oz Gruyère, 8 oz Fontina and 4 oz Comté or extra Gruyère with $1\frac{1}{2}$ tbsp cornstarch, 1 cup dry white wine and 1 tbsp lemon juice. Follow the same gradual melting method. Finish with 1 tsp Dijon, 1–2 tsp chives, black pepper, a pinch of nutmeg and an optional 1 tbsp Kirsch.

Cheddar and Gruyere fondue

Use 12 oz sharp white cheddar, 4 oz Gruyère, 1 tbsp cornstarch, $\frac{3}{4}$ cup dry white wine, 1 garlic clove, 1 tsp Dijon and 1 tsp lemon juice. Melt gently as above; add black pepper and an optional pinch of garlic powder.

Keeping it smooth

Grate from a block for an even melt. Avoid boiling after the cheese goes in. If the fondue thickens, stir in warm wine one tablespoon at a time. Reheat any refrigerated leftovers gently to 165°F, stirring and thinning as needed.

Two starter soups

Lobster bisque September 2026 • Spring soup April 2026

Trader Joes lobster bisque with buttered lobster

Serves 2 as a starter • 15 minutes

Ingredients. 2 cups prepared lobster bisque; 1 tsp plus 1 tbsp butter; 1 tbsp minced shallot; 1 tbsp dry sherry; 3–4 oz cooked lobster; ¼ tsp lemon juice, plus a little zest; black pepper; 2 tsp crème fraîche; chives; 2 thin sourdough slices.

1. Soften shallot in 1 tsp butter. Add sherry and reduce by half. Stir in bisque and heat gently according to its package.
2. In another small pan, warm lobster in 1 tbsp butter. Add a little lemon zest and pepper. Finish bisque with lemon juice; taste before adding salt.
3. Brush bread with a little oil or butter and toast at 400°F for 6–10 minutes. Divide lobster between bowls, pour in soup and finish with loosened crème fraîche and chives.

For the table: bring warmed soup in a small jug and pour around the lobster. Keep the toppings simple.

Chilled pea and mint soup shots

Makes 8 small shots or 4 starters • 25 minutes plus chilling

Ingredients. 1 tbsp butter; 1 small shallot, chopped; 3 cups frozen peas; 2 cups vegetable stock; ¼ cup mint leaves; 2 tbsp crème fraîche, plus garnish; 1 tsp lemon juice; 2 tbsp chopped pistachios; olive oil; salt.

1. Soften shallot in butter. Add stock and bring to a simmer; add peas and cook 3–4 minutes until tender.
2. Blend with mint and crème fraîche until smooth. Cool quickly in a shallow container and refrigerate. Add lemon and salt to taste. Serve in small glasses with pistachios and a few drops of olive oil.

Classic cheese souffle

January 2026

Serves 4 • 25 minutes prep • About 15–20 minutes baking

Ingredients. 3 tbsp unsalted butter, plus more for ramekins; 3 tbsp all-purpose flour; 1 cup warm whole milk; 4 oz finely grated Gruyère or cheddar; 4 eggs, separated; ½ tsp kosher salt; ¼ tsp black pepper; pinch of nutmeg; ½ tsp Dijon, optional; 2 tbsp grated Parmesan for ramekins.

1. Heat the oven to 400°F with a rack in the lower middle. Butter four 8 oz ramekins and coat lightly with Parmesan. Place on a sheet pan.
2. Melt 3 tbsp butter in a saucepan. Whisk in flour and cook for 1 minute without browning. Slowly whisk in warm milk; simmer 2–3 minutes until smooth and thick.
3. Take off the heat. Stir in cheese, salt, pepper, nutmeg and optional Dijon. Cool for 2 minutes, then whisk in egg yolks one at a time.
4. In a clean bowl, beat the whites to soft peaks. Stir one quarter into the cheese mixture to loosen it, then gently fold in the remainder in two additions.
5. Divide among ramekins, filling to about ¾ full. Run a fingertip around the inside edge. Bake until risen, golden and set in the center, beginning checks at 15 minutes; the center should reach 160°F. Serve immediately.

Have the plates and guests ready before the soufflés leave the oven. The batter loses volume if left waiting after the whites are folded in.

Soft shell crab sandwiches

An original home version of the earlier cookbook inspired idea

Makes 2 sandwiches • 30 minutes active • 2–3 hours for tomato confit

Ingredients. 2 cleaned soft-shell crabs; 2 brioche buns; ¼ cup flour; ¼ cup cornstarch; ½ tsp paprika; ½ tsp salt; 2 tbsp neutral oil; 1 tbsp butter; lettuce. Tomato confit: 4 Roma tomatoes, 2 tbsp olive oil, 1 sliced garlic clove, 2 thyme sprigs, a pinch each salt and sugar. Sauce: 3 tbsp mayonnaise, 1 tsp lemon juice, 1 tsp capers, chopped.

1. For confit, heat oven to 200°F. Peel tomatoes if desired, halve and remove seeds. Toss with oil, garlic, thyme, salt and sugar. Place cut-side up and roast for 2–3 hours until soft and concentrated. Refrigerate promptly if making ahead.
2. Ask the fishmonger to clean the crabs, including removing the gills, apron and face. Pat dry. Combine flour, cornstarch, paprika and salt; dust the crabs lightly and shake off excess.
3. Heat oil and butter in a skillet over medium-high heat. Cook crabs for about 3–4 minutes per side, adjusting heat to prevent burning, until crisp and the flesh is opaque throughout.
4. Mix sauce ingredients. Toast buns. Layer sauce, lettuce, tomato confit and a crab on each bun. Eat immediately while the shell is crisp.

The slow tomato confit can be made the day before. This is a practical home recipe for the sandwich concept, with a simple lemon-caper sauce.

Caviar tasting dishes

Home versions of the January 2026 ideas

Warm potato puree with caviar

Serves 4 as a small starter • 30 minutes

Ingredients. 1 lb Yukon Gold potatoes; 3 tbsp butter; ¼ cup warm milk or cream; salt; 20–30 g caviar; chives.

1. Peel and cube potatoes. Simmer in salted water until tender, 15–20 minutes. Drain, steam-dry and pass through a ricer.
2. Fold in butter and warm milk until smooth. Spoon small portions into warm cups. Add caviar and chives when the purée is warm rather than steaming.

Salmon tartare cornets

Makes 12 • 25 minutes

Ingredients. 12 baked wonton cones; 8 oz salmon intended for raw service, finely diced; 1 tbsp shallot, minced and rinsed; 1 tsp olive oil; 1 tsp lemon juice; 2 tbsp crème fraîche; 1 tsp chives.

1. Prepare cones using the method in the tuna tartare recipe. Keep them dry. Mix salmon, shallot, oil and lemon just before service.
2. Put a little crème fraîche in each cone, then salmon and chives. Serve at once. Follow the raw seafood notes.

Creamy tapioca with oysters and caviar

Serves 4 in tasting portions • About 35 minutes

Ingredients. 2 tbsp small pearl tapioca, not instant; ¾ cup milk; ¼ cup cream; ¼ cup clam juice; 4 shucked oysters; 1 tbsp butter; 20 g caviar; chives.

1. Soak tapioca if its package requires it. Simmer in milk, cream and clam juice, stirring and adding water as needed, until the pearls are tender and the mixture is spoonable, usually 20–30 minutes.
2. Add oysters and cook gently until their flesh is opaque and fully cooked. Stir in butter. Divide into warm small bowls. Let cool briefly, then add caviar and chives.

This is a simplified home interpretation of the Oysters and Pearls concept.

Steak au poivre

Kelli birthday menu • Jorts and Forks autumn menu

Serves 2 • About 40 minutes

Ingredients. 2 steaks, 8–10 oz each; 1 tbsp coarsely cracked black pepper; salt; 1 tbsp neutral oil; 2 tbsp butter, divided; 1 small shallot, minced; 2 tbsp brandy or cognac; ½ cup beef stock; ½ cup heavy cream; 1 tsp Dijon, optional. To serve: roasted fennel, asparagus and a small fresh truffle, optional.

1. Pat steaks dry. Season with salt and press cracked pepper onto both sides. Heat oil in a heavy skillet over medium-high heat.
2. Sear steaks, about 2–3 minutes per side to establish a crust. Add 1 tbsp butter and baste; lower the heat or finish in a 400°F oven as needed. Use a thermometer; the standard minimum is 145°F followed by at least 3 minutes rest.
3. Transfer steaks to a warm plate. Pour off excess fat, leaving a thin film. Soften shallot over medium heat for 1–2 minutes.
4. Move the pan off the burner before adding brandy. Return to the heat and simmer until nearly evaporated. Add stock; reduce by about half.
5. Add cream and simmer gently for 3–5 minutes until the sauce coats a spoon. Stir in optional Dijon, the remaining butter and resting juices. Taste for salt.
6. Spoon sauce onto warm plates, add steak and vegetables, then shave a little fresh truffle over the finished dish if using.

Autumn menu version: use wagyu steaks, sauté 8 oz sliced shiitakes separately and add alongside the sauce. Serve with roasted garlic mashed potatoes and buttered asparagus. For prep ahead, make the sauce without steak drippings a day ahead; finish in the steak pan at service.

Dirty martini steak frites

September 17 2026

Serves 2 • About 40 minutes with frozen fries

Ingredients. 2 NY strip steaks, 10–12 oz each; 12–16 oz frozen shoestring fries; 1 tbsp neutral oil; salt and pepper. Sauce: 1 shallot, minced; 1 garlic clove, minced; 2 tbsp gin; ¼ cup dry vermouth; ½ cup beef stock; ⅓ cup heavy cream; ⅓ cup green olives, chopped; 1 tbsp olive brine, plus more to taste; 1 tbsp butter; ¼ tsp lemon zest.

1. Cook fries according to the package, spreading them out so they crisp. Keep hot while finishing the steak and sauce.
2. Pat steaks dry, season and sear in hot oil for 2–3 minutes per side to form a crust. Continue over lower heat as needed until 145°F, then rest for 7–10 minutes.
3. Pour off excess pan fat. Soften shallot for 2 minutes; add garlic for 30 seconds. Remove pan from the heat to add gin and vermouth. Return to the burner and reduce until only a little liquid remains.
4. Add stock and reduce by half. Add cream and simmer until it lightly coats a spoon. Turn the heat low and stir in olives, brine, butter and lemon zest.
5. Taste before salting; the olives and brine may be enough. Slice the steak and serve with the fries. Spoon sauce beside or over the steak just before eating.

Homemade frites: cut 1¼ lb russets into thin sticks, soak in cold water 30 minutes, then dry very thoroughly. Fry in small batches at 325°F for 4–6 minutes; cool on a rack. Fry again at 375°F for 2–3 minutes until golden. Never add wet potatoes to hot oil.

Reverse seared steak and herb butter

Jorts and Forks Spring Steakhouse Edition • April 2026

Serves 4 • 15 minutes prep • About 45–75 minutes cooking and resting

Ingredients. 2 thick steaks, about 1 lb each and 1½–2 inches thick; 1 tbsp neutral oil; salt and pepper. Butter: 4 tbsp soft butter; 1 minced garlic clove; 1 tbsp parsley; 1 tbsp chives; ½ tsp lemon zest; ½ tsp Dijon; black pepper. Raspberry balsamic sauce from the venison recipe, optional.

1. Mix the compound butter ingredients. Roll in parchment or place in a small bowl; refrigerate until needed.
2. Heat oven to 250°F. Season the steaks and put them on a rack over a tray. Roast until the centers reach about 130–135°F, beginning checks after 25 minutes; thickness matters more than the clock.
3. Heat a heavy skillet until very hot and add oil. Sear the steaks for 1–2 minutes per side, then sear the edges. Continue until the center reaches 145°F.
4. Rest for at least 3 minutes, ideally 5–10 minutes for easier slicing. Slice across the grain and serve family-style with herb butter and optional warm raspberry sauce.

Prep ahead: make the butter and raspberry sauce 1–2 days ahead. Serve with truffle Parmesan potatoes and charred asparagus.

Steak a la Parker

For the summer menu, use this same steak method and finish with the herb butter. Pair with bacon herb potato salad, asparagus and street corn casserole.

Names from the football dinner brainstorm

The December 2025 naming ideas included Drake Maye's Fourth-Quarter Ribeye, Maye Day Prime Filet, Red Zone Ribeye, The Clutch Drive New York Strip, Pocket-Perfect Filet Mignon and Patriot Power Porterhouse. Choose the name that matches the cut you actually serve.

Venison with raspberry balsamic sauce

January 30 2026

Serves 2 to 3 • About 40 minutes

Ingredients. 1 lb venison tenderloin, trimmed; 1 tbsp neutral oil; salt and pepper. Sauce: 1 cup raspberries; 1 shallot, minced; 1 tbsp butter plus ½ tbsp to finish; 1 tsp olive oil; 2–3 tbsp balsamic vinegar; ¼ cup stock; 1–2 tsp honey or brown sugar; thyme or rosemary, optional.

1. For the sauce, soften shallot in 1 tbsp butter and 1 tsp oil for 2–3 minutes. Add raspberries and cook for 3–4 minutes, crushing them.
2. Add balsamic, stock, sweetener and optional herbs. Simmer 8–12 minutes until reduced by about half. Strain if desired, then whisk in ½ tbsp cold butter.
3. Pat venison dry, season and sear in neutral oil over medium-high heat until browned on all sides. Finish in a 375°F oven as needed, checking the thickest part with a thermometer. FoodSafety.gov lists 160°F for venison.
4. Rest for 5–10 minutes. Slice across the grain and spoon the sauce around the meat. Serve with truffle Parmesan fries, lemon asparagus and carrot purée.

Whipped carrot puree

Serves 4 as a side • 30 minutes

Ingredients. 1 lb carrots, peeled and sliced; 2 tbsp butter; ¼ cup warm cream, plus more if needed; 1 tsp honey; salt and white pepper; pinch ginger or thyme, optional.

1. Simmer carrots in lightly salted water for 15–20 minutes until very soft. Drain thoroughly.
2. Blend with butter, cream and honey until smooth. Add a little more warm cream if needed. Season and keep warm; garnish with a few thyme leaves if using.

Venison and Momofuku noodle bowls

September 2 2026

Venison noodles with white miso sesame sauce

Serves 2 to 3 • 25 minutes using cooked venison

Ingredients. 8–10 oz cooked venison roast, thinly sliced; 2 packets Momofuku noodles; 2–3 eggs; 2 scallions; sesame seeds; chili crisp. Sauce: 2 tbsp white miso, 1½ tbsp soy sauce, 1 tbsp rice vinegar, 1 tbsp sesame oil, 1 tbsp honey or brown sugar, 1 tsp ginger, 1 small garlic clove, 1–2 tsp chili crisp and 2–4 tbsp warm water.

1. Cook eggs to your preferred set; use pasteurized eggs for a soft yolk. Whisk the sauce ingredients until smooth.
2. Boil noodles according to their package. Reserve some cooking water. Drain and toss with the miso sauce, loosening with water as needed. Add the packet sauce only after tasting, since both sauces are salty.
3. Reheat leftover venison gently with a splash of stock to 165°F. Divide noodles into bowls and add venison, halved eggs, scallions, sesame and chili crisp. Add 1–2 tbsp hot roast juices if available.

Miso butter sauce

For the same quantity of noodles, melt 2 tbsp butter. Remove from the heat and whisk in 1 tbsp white miso, 1 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tsp honey, 1 tsp rice vinegar, 1 small grated garlic clove and a splash of hot water or roast juices. Toss into hot noodles.

Miso chili crisp sauce

Mix 1½ tbsp white miso, 1 tbsp each chili crisp, soy sauce and rice vinegar, 1 tsp each sesame oil and honey, and 2 tbsp hot water. Toss with noodles and add more water to loosen.

Cooking a fresh roast

For a small boneless venison roast, season, sear all sides and roast at 325°F until the thickest part reaches 160°F. Rest 10 minutes before slicing. The roasting time depends on the cut and thickness; use temperature rather than a fixed time.

Fig leaf wrapped branzino

September 2026 • With lemon brown butter

Serves 2 • 25 minutes prep • About 20–30 minutes cooking

Ingredients. 1 cleaned whole branzino, 1–1½ lb; 6–8 clean culinary fig leaves from an unsprayed common fig tree; 1 lemon; 2 garlic cloves, sliced; 4 thyme or oregano sprigs; 1 tbsp olive oil; salt and pepper; a few fennel slices, optional. Sauce: 3 tbsp butter, juice of ½ lemon, 1 tbsp olive oil, 1 tbsp parsley, 1 tsp capers, optional.

1. Heat a grill for indirect cooking at about 400°F. Briefly blanch leaves in boiling water for 15 seconds, then cool and dry. If fig leaves are unavailable, use parchment and follow the oven option; do not put parchment on the grill.
2. Pat fish dry, including the cavity. Make 2 shallow slashes on each side. Season and stuff with lemon slices, garlic, herbs and optional fennel. Rub with oil.
3. Overlap leaves into a large sheet, place the fish in the center and wrap snugly. Tie with kitchen twine. Put over indirect heat, cover and cook for 18–25 minutes, turning carefully once. Continue until the fish reaches 145°F in the thickest flesh.
4. For a little char, move the leaf parcel over direct heat for 1–2 minutes, watching closely. Rest briefly, open the parcel and discard the leaves and twine.
5. Brown butter in a small saucepan until nutty. Remove from the heat; carefully add lemon juice, oil, parsley and optional capers. Spoon over the fish after removing the backbone and checking for pin bones.

Oven option: roast the wrapped fish at 400°F on a tray and check for 145°F. The seasonal menu also used lemon herb beurre blanc; its recipe appears with the sauces.

More fig leaf ideas

September 2026 • The leaves form an aromatic wrapper

Wrapping method

Use washed, unsprayed common fig leaves intended for culinary use. Blanch for 15 seconds, cool and dry. Overlap around the filling and tie or secure in a baking dish. Unwrap to serve; discard the leaves. Avoid decorative florist leaves.

Goat cheese or feta parcels

Serves 4 • 20 minutes

Ingredients. 8 oz goat cheese or feta; 4 large fig leaves; 1 tbsp olive oil; 2 tsp honey; 1 tsp thyme; black pepper.

1. Divide cheese among leaves. Add oil, honey, thyme and pepper. Wrap and bake at 375°F for 10–15 minutes, until softened. Serve with toast.

Halloumi with honey and lemon

Wrap four 2 oz slabs of halloumi with a little olive oil, honey and lemon zest. Grill over medium indirect heat for 8–12 minutes, turning once, until warm and softened.

Chicken thighs with garlic and oregano

Coat 4 boneless thighs with 1 tbsp oil, 1 minced garlic clove, 1 tbsp lemon juice, 1 tsp oregano, salt and pepper. Wrap in leaves and roast at 400°F for about 25–35 minutes, until the chicken reaches 165°F.

Lamb with rosemary

Season four small lamb loin portions with olive oil, garlic, rosemary and lemon zest. Sear briefly, wrap and finish at 400°F until 145°F; rest at least 3 minutes.

Herbed rice parcels

Mix 2 cups cooked rice, ¼ cup chopped parsley and dill, 2 tbsp toasted pine nuts, 1 tbsp lemon juice and 1 tbsp oil. Wrap in 6 leaves, place in a dish with ¼ cup water, cover and bake at 375°F for 20 minutes until hot. An optional ½ lb ground lamb should be browned to 160°F before mixing in.

Miso black cod or another fish

For two 6 oz fillets, mix 1 tbsp white miso, 1 tbsp mirin, 1 tsp honey, ½ tsp ginger and 1 scallion. Spread on fish, wrap and bake at 400°F for 15–20 minutes, until 145°F. Salmon, cod, halibut and sea bass also work.

Duck breast with fig wine sauce

Parker birthday menu • August 2026

Serves 2 • About 50 minutes

Ingredients. 2 duck breasts, about 8 oz each; salt and pepper. Sauce: 1 shallot, minced; 1 tbsp butter plus 1–2 tbsp cold butter; 4–6 fresh figs, chopped; ½ cup red wine or port; 1–2 tbsp balsamic vinegar; ½ cup chicken or duck stock; 1 thyme sprig; ½–1 tsp honey. To serve: roasted rainbow carrots, fennel and crispy baby potatoes.

1. Pat duck dry. Score the skin in a shallow crosshatch, cutting through the fat without cutting the flesh. Season.
2. Place skin-side down in a cold dry skillet. Set over medium-low heat and render slowly for 10–15 minutes, pouring off excess fat into a heatproof bowl. Increase heat briefly if needed to crisp the skin.
3. Turn and cook the flesh side for 2–3 minutes. Finish in a 375°F oven until the thickest part reaches 165°F. Rest 5–10 minutes, skin-side up.
4. For sauce, soften shallot in 1 tbsp butter. Add figs, wine, balsamic, stock, thyme, honey and pepper. Simmer 10–15 minutes until the figs soften and the sauce reduces.
5. Remove thyme and strain if you want a smooth sauce. Off the heat, whisk in 1–2 tbsp cold butter. Season.
6. Slice the duck and spoon sauce beside it to preserve the crisp skin. Serve with the roasted vegetables and potatoes.

Prep ahead: make the sauce through the reduction the day before. Reheat, then add the finishing butter at service. Save strained duck fat for potatoes.

Korean barbecue duck dinner

November 2025

KBBQ duck over butternut squash

Serves 2 • 30 minutes active • 1–4 hours marinating

Ingredients. 2 duck breasts; 2 tbsp soy sauce; 1 tbsp grated pear; 1 tbsp brown sugar; 1 tsp sesame oil; 1 garlic clove; 1 tsp ginger; 1 scallion. Purée: 1½ lb peeled butternut squash cubes, 1 tbsp oil, 2 tbsp butter, 2–4 tbsp cream, salt.

1. Mix soy, pear, sugar, sesame oil, grated garlic, ginger and scallion. Score duck skin. Place the flesh in the marinade while keeping the skin as dry as possible. Refrigerate 1–4 hours.
2. Roast squash with oil and salt at 400°F for 30–40 minutes until tender. Blend with butter and enough cream for a smooth purée.
3. Remove duck from marinade and wipe dry, particularly the sugary surface. Discard used marinade. Start skin-side down in a cold skillet and render over medium-low heat for 10–15 minutes, pouring off excess fat.
4. Turn to brown the flesh, then finish in a 375°F oven to 165°F. Rest 5–10 minutes. Slice and serve over squash with one or two banchan dishes.

Duck fat potatoes with raclette

Serves 2 to 3 • 45 minutes

Ingredients. 1 lb baby potatoes; 2 tbsp rendered duck fat; salt and pepper; 3 oz raclette, sliced.

1. Halve potatoes and simmer in salted water for 8–10 minutes until almost tender. Drain and steam-dry.
2. Toss with duck fat and roast at 425°F for 25–30 minutes, turning once, until crisp. Add raclette and return to the oven for 2–3 minutes until melted.

Banchan for the duck menu

November 2025 • Choose two or three

Cucumber oi muchim

Serves 4 in small portions • 15 minutes

Ingredients. 1 large cucumber; ½ tsp salt; 1 tbsp rice vinegar; 1 tsp sugar; 1 tsp gochugaru; 1 tsp sesame oil; 1 scallion; 1 tsp sesame seeds.

1. Slice cucumber, toss with salt and drain for 10 minutes. Pat dry, then toss with the remaining ingredients. Serve soon for the best crunch.

Charred scallion sesame spinach

Serves 4 in small portions • 15 minutes

Ingredients. 8 oz spinach; 4 scallions; 1 tsp neutral oil; 1 tsp sesame oil; 1 tsp soy sauce; 1 tsp sesame seeds.

1. Wilt spinach in a hot pan with a splash of water, then cool and squeeze dry. Char scallions in neutral oil. Chop and toss with spinach, sesame oil, soy and seeds.

Honey gochugaru lotus root

For 4 small portions, simmer 8 oz peeled thinly sliced lotus root for 8–10 minutes; drain. Sauté in 1 tsp oil, then add 1 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tbsp honey, 2 tbsp water and ½ tsp gochugaru. Reduce until glossy.

Miso roasted eggplant

Halve 2 small eggplants, score and brush with oil. Roast cut-side down at 425°F for 20–25 minutes. Turn, spread with 1 tbsp miso mixed with 1 tsp honey and 1 tsp rice vinegar, and roast 5 minutes more.

White pear and daikon side

For a quick, unfermented alternative to the white kimchi idea, toss 1 cup thin daikon, ½ sliced pear, 1 tbsp rice vinegar, 1 tsp sugar and ¼ tsp salt. Chill 30 minutes. Use prepared baek kimchi for the fermented version.

Lettuce or perilla wraps

Set out washed lettuce or culinary perilla leaves, cooked short-grain rice and ssamjang. Let guests wrap small slices of duck with the rice and a little sauce.

Crispy salmon with miso fig glaze

Trader Joes dinner • September 15 2026

Serves 2 • About 40 minutes

Ingredients. 2 skin-on salmon fillets, about 6 oz each; 1 fennel bulb, sliced; 1 leek, thoroughly washed and sliced; 2 tbsp olive oil; salt and pepper. Glaze: 2 ripe figs, mashed; 1½ tbsp white miso; 1 tbsp soy sauce; 1 tbsp honey or maple syrup; 1 tsp rice vinegar or citrus juice; 1 tsp sesame oil, optional; 1–2 tbsp water. Salad: ½ cucumber, ¼ cup cilantro and a squeeze of lime. Extra fresh figs for plating, optional.

1. Heat oven to 425°F. Toss fennel and leek with 1 tbsp oil, salt and pepper. Roast for 20–25 minutes, turning once; cover loosely if the leek browns too quickly.
2. Mix glaze ingredients until smooth, adding water to make a brushable sauce. Slice cucumber and toss with cilantro and lime.
3. Dry salmon well. Put remaining oil in an oven-safe skillet and place salmon skin-side down in the cold pan. Set over medium heat. Cook 5–7 minutes, pressing gently at first so the skin contacts the pan.
4. Turn fish for about 1 minute. Turn skin-side down again and brush the flesh with glaze. Broil briefly, about 1–2 minutes, watching the sugar closely. If more cooking is needed, finish at 375°F until the center reaches 145°F.
5. Place fennel and leeks slightly off-center on each plate. Add salmon, spoon a little warm glaze nearby and put the cucumber salad to one side. Add fresh fig quarters if using.

Keep the extra sauce separate from any brush that touched raw salmon. If sauce does contact raw fish, cook it thoroughly before serving.

Trader Joes flatbreads and pita

Five additional dinner ideas • September 2026

Crispy beef birria lavash flatbread

Serves 2 • 20 minutes

Ingredients. 1 large lavash; 1 cup cooked beef birria, drained; ½ cup mozzarella; ½ cup thinly sliced fennel; ¼ cup tzatziki; ½ cup chopped cucumber; cilantro.

1. Heat oven to 450°F. Warm birria as directed on the package. Spread lavash with a thin layer of tzatziki, then add beef, mozzarella and fennel.
2. Bake 7–10 minutes until crisp. Add cucumber and cilantro. For a firmer crust, put most of the tzatziki on after baking.

Mediterranean beef kebab pita

Serves 2 • 25 minutes

Ingredients. 2 pitas; 8 oz beef kebab; ¼ cup tzatziki; 1 cup romaine; ½ cucumber; ½ fennel bulb; 1 tbsp oil; cilantro; 2 tbsp toasted herb breadcrumbs.

1. Cook kebab according to its package; raw ground-beef kebab should reach 160°F. Sauté thin fennel in oil until browned. Warm pitas.
2. Fill with tzatziki, romaine, cucumber, beef, fennel and cilantro. Finish with herb crumbs.

Fig mozzarella and caramelized leek flatbread

Serves 2 • 30 minutes

Ingredients. 1 lavash; 1 large leek, washed and sliced; 1 tbsp butter or oil; ¾ cup mozzarella; 3 figs, sliced; black pepper; 1 tsp hot honey or balsamic glaze.

1. Cook leek slowly in butter for 10–15 minutes until soft. Top lavash with mozzarella, leek and figs.
2. Bake at 425°F for 8–12 minutes until crisp. Finish with pepper and hot honey or balsamic. Optional additions: prosciutto, cooked bacon, goat cheese or blue cheese.

A scallion pancake wrap and gnocchi

Trader Joes dinner ideas • September 2026

Crispy Taiwanese scallion pancake beef wrap

Makes 2 wraps • 25 minutes

Ingredients. 2 frozen Taiwanese scallion pancakes; 8 oz beef kebab or cooked birria; ½ cucumber, cut into sticks; 1 cup romaine; cilantro; 1 sliced scallion. Sauce: 2 tbsp mayo, 1 tbsp soy, 1 tsp sriracha or chili crisp, 1 tsp rice vinegar, ½ tsp honey.

1. Mix the sauce. Cook beef as directed, breaking it into small pieces; raw ground beef should reach 160°F.
2. Pan-cook pancakes according to the package until very crisp. Spread with a little sauce and add beef, cucumber, romaine, cilantro and scallion.
3. Roll tightly and cut in half. Add a fried egg if desired, or use reheated leftover birria in place of kebab.

Cauliflower gnocchi with creamy corn and leeks

Serves 2 to 3 • 30 minutes

Ingredients. 1 bag cauliflower gnocchi, about 12 oz; 2 tbsp olive oil, divided; 1 leek, washed and chopped; 1 cup prepared creamy corn; ¼ cup stock or milk; ½ cup mozzarella; ¼ cup herb breadcrumbs; cilantro; black pepper.

1. Pan-sear gnocchi in 1 tbsp oil according to package directions until golden. Remove to a plate.
2. Cook leek in ½ tbsp oil until soft and browned, about 10 minutes. Stir in creamy corn and stock or milk. Simmer gently; add mozzarella and stir until melted.
3. Toast breadcrumbs in remaining oil in a small skillet. Fold gnocchi into sauce just before serving. Add crumbs, cilantro and black pepper. Optional finishes: Parmesan or chili crisp.

Turkey mushroom and leek cooking base

March 28 2025 • A foundation for the recipe variations

Savory turkey mushroom and leek skillet

Makes 4 servings • 30 minutes

Ingredients. 1 lb ground turkey; 8 oz mushrooms, finely chopped; 1 large leek, white and light green parts; 1 tbsp olive oil; 2 garlic cloves, minced; ½ tsp dried thyme; ½ tsp salt, plus more to taste; black pepper; ¼ cup stock.

1. Halve the leek lengthwise, rinse thoroughly between layers and slice. Heat oil in a wide skillet. Brown mushrooms over medium-high heat for 6–8 minutes so their liquid evaporates.
2. Add leek and cook for 4–5 minutes. Stir in garlic and thyme for 30 seconds.
3. Add turkey and break it into small pieces. Cook until no longer pink and it reaches 165°F. Add stock, salt and pepper and simmer 2 minutes. Taste and adjust.
4. Serve immediately or cool promptly in shallow containers. Refrigerate for up to 3–4 days or freeze in meal-size portions. Reheat to 165°F.

How to use the following variations

Unless a variation specifies otherwise, use one full batch of this cooked base for four servings. The add-ins below turn it into a complete meal. Meatballs, patties, skewers and Wellington have separate instructions because they need a bound filling.

A richer tart from the original conversation

For 6 appetizer portions, make the base with 1 cup chopped mushrooms. Cool, then fold in ¼ cup crème fraîche and ½ cup Gruyère. Spread inside the scored border of one puff pastry sheet. Brush the border with beaten egg and bake at 400°F for 25–30 minutes until crisp.

Turkey skillet variations

March 2025 • Quick meals from one batch of the cooking base

Ground turkey and mushroom stir fry

Add 2 cups broccoli or mixed vegetables to the pan and cook until tender. Stir in 2 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tsp grated ginger and 1 tsp sesame oil. Serve over 2 cups cooked rice.

Turkey mushroom and leek lettuce wraps

Spoon the base into 12 butter-lettuce leaves. Add cucumber, scallion and a little soy-lime sauce. For the avocado-cucumber salsa version, toss 1 diced avocado and ½ cucumber with lime and cilantro before topping.

Turkey and mushroom rice bowl

Divide 2 cups cooked rice among four bowls and top with the base, sliced scallions, a drizzle of sesame oil and a squeeze of lime.

Turkey and mushroom tacos

Warm 8 small tortillas. Season the base with 1 tsp cumin and 1 tsp chili powder, then fill tortillas and add salsa. For the mango version, combine 1 diced mango, 1 avocado, lime juice and cilantro.

Turkey and mushroom skillet with eggs

Make four wells in the hot base, crack in 4 eggs, cover and cook over low heat until the eggs set. Use pasteurized eggs if you prefer a softer yolk.

Turkey and mushroom sweet potato hash

Dice 1 lb sweet potatoes and roast with 1 tbsp oil at 425°F for 25–30 minutes. Fold into the hot base; finish with parsley and optional fried eggs.

Turkey mushroom and leek soup

Add 4 cups stock, 1 diced carrot and 1 cup cooked beans or rice to the base. Simmer 15 minutes; stir in 2 cups spinach until wilted. Finish with lemon.

Turkey and mushroom cottage cheese bowls

Divide 2 cups cottage cheese among bowls. Add warm turkey base, 2 cups cooked broccoli and chopped cucumber. Finish with scallion and black pepper.

Turkey bakes and stuffed vegetables

March 2025 • Use one batch of the cooked base for each recipe

Turkey and mushroom shepherds pie

Spread the base in a greased baking dish with 1 cup peas and ½ cup stock. Cover with 3 cups mashed potatoes. Bake at 400°F for 25–30 minutes until bubbling and 165°F in the center.

Turkey and mushroom stuffed peppers

Halve and seed 4 bell peppers; roast at 400°F for 15 minutes. Fill with the base mixed with 1 cup cooked rice and ½ cup tomato sauce. Add ½ cup cheese; bake 20–25 minutes more. Optional avocado cream: blend 1 avocado, ¼ cup yogurt and lime juice.

Turkey and mushroom cabbage rolls

Blanch 8 large cabbage leaves until flexible. Fill with the base mixed with 1 cup cooked rice. Roll, place seam-side down in 2 cups tomato sauce, cover and bake at 375°F for 35–45 minutes until hot throughout.

Turkey and mushroom zucchini boats

Halve 4 zucchini and scoop out centers. Fill with the base, top with ½ cup mozzarella, and bake at 400°F for 25–30 minutes until tender and hot.

Turkey mushroom and leek casserole

Mix the base with 8 oz cooked pasta, ½ cup crème fraîche, ½ cup stock and ½ cup Gruyère. Transfer to a dish, top with ¼ cup breadcrumbs and bake at 375°F for 20–25 minutes until the center reaches 165°F.

Turkey and mushroom stuffed portobellos

Remove stems and gills from 4 large caps. Brush with oil and roast at 400°F for 10 minutes; drain liquid. Fill with the base, add ½ cup Gruyère and bake 15–20 minutes more.

Creamy turkey mushroom and leek galette

Cool the base, stir in ¼ cup crème fraîche and mound onto one 12-inch round of pie dough, leaving a 2-inch border. Fold the edge over, brush with egg and bake at 400°F for 35–45 minutes until golden.

Turkey pasta risotto and polenta

March 2025 • Four servings each

Creamy turkey and mushroom pasta

Cook 12 oz pasta. Warm one batch of the turkey base with ½ cup cream and ½ cup pasta water. Toss with pasta and ¼ cup Parmesan. For the broccoli and green onion variation, add 2 cups broccoli to the pasta pot for its last 3 minutes, then finish with 2 sliced green onions.

Turkey leek and mushroom Bolognese

Add 2 tbsp tomato paste to one batch of the base and cook 1 minute. Add one 14 oz can crushed tomatoes and ½ cup stock; simmer 20 minutes. Toss with 12 oz cooked pappardelle and finish with Parmesan.

Herbed turkey and mushroom risotto

Soften 1 shallot in 1 tbsp butter, stir in 1 cup arborio rice, then add ¼ cup white wine. Add about 4 cups hot stock gradually, stirring until rice is tender, about 20 minutes. Fold in the hot base, ⅓ cup Parmesan and 1 tbsp parsley.

Turkey mushroom and leek ragu with polenta

Simmer one batch of the base with 1 cup crushed tomatoes, ½ cup stock and a rosemary sprig for 20 minutes. Cook 1 cup dry polenta in 4 cups water according to its package, then stir in 2 tbsp butter and ¼ cup Parmesan. Spoon the ragu over the polenta.

Turkey cannelloni with bechamel

Cool one batch of the base and stir in ½ cup ricotta. Fill 12 cooked cannelloni tubes. Make béchamel by cooking 2 tbsp butter with 2 tbsp flour for 1 minute, then whisking in 2 cups milk and simmering until thick. Spread a little sauce in a dish, add pasta, cover with the rest and ½ cup Parmesan. Bake at 375°F for 30–35 minutes to 165°F in the center.

Turkey patties meatballs and pastry

March 2025 • Use raw turkey for these bound mixtures

Turkey mushroom and leek meatballs

Finely chop 8 oz mushrooms and 1 washed leek. Cook in 1 tbsp oil until dry and cool completely. Mix with 1 lb raw turkey, 1 egg, ½ cup breadcrumbs, ½ tsp salt and pepper. Form 16 meatballs and bake at 400°F for 18–22 minutes, until 165°F.

Seared patties with leek cream

Make the same mixture and form 8 patties. Sear in a lightly oiled pan for 4–5 minutes per side, until 165°F. For sauce, soften 1 sliced leek in 1 tbsp butter, add ½ cup stock and ¼ cup cream, and simmer 5–8 minutes. Spoon around the patties.

Turkey mushroom skewers with yogurt cucumber dip

Form the cooled vegetable-and-raw-turkey mixture around 8 flat skewers. Broil or grill over medium heat, turning, until 165°F throughout. Mix ½ cup Greek yogurt, ¼ grated cucumber squeezed dry, 1 tsp lemon juice and a pinch of salt for the dip.

Turkey sliders with avocado cream

Shape the same mixture into 8 small patties and pan-cook to 165°F. Serve on slider buns with mashed avocado mixed with yogurt and lime. Add thin cucumber tossed with lemon and a pinch of salt for a quick slaw.

Turkey mushroom and leek croquettes

Mix 2 cups finely chopped cooked base with 1 cup cold mashed potato and ¼ cup Parmesan. Form 12 small logs; chill 30 minutes. Coat in flour, beaten egg and breadcrumbs. Shallow-fry in 350°F oil until crisp and 165°F inside. Serve with mayonnaise mixed with grated garlic and lemon.

Turkey and mushroom Wellington

Bake the raw turkey mixture as a compact log at 375°F until 165°F, about 30–40 minutes; cool promptly and chill. Wrap in one puff pastry sheet with seams underneath, brush with egg and bake at 400°F until golden and reheated to 165°F, about 30–40 minutes.

Turkey bowls and breakfast ideas

March 2025 • The additional ingredient variations

Power bowl with broccoli avocado and mango salsa

For four bowls, roast 3 cups broccoli with 1 tbsp oil at 425°F for 18–22 minutes. Divide 2 cups cooked grain and one hot batch of the turkey base among bowls. Add broccoli, 1 sliced avocado and salsa made from 1 diced mango, lime and cilantro.

Grain bowl with avocado dressing

Use the same grain, turkey and broccoli quantities. Blend 1 avocado, ¼ cup yogurt, juice of ½ lime and water to a pourable dressing. Spoon over bowls.

Turkey and mushroom stuffed avocado

Halve 2 large avocados. Fill with about 2 cups warm turkey base and top with green onion, cooked leek and lime. Serve extra filling alongside. This makes 4 light portions.

Turkey mushroom and leek frittata

Whisk 6 eggs with ¼ cup milk. Stir in 2 cups cooled turkey base and season lightly. Pour into an oiled oven-safe skillet. Cook over medium-low heat for 2 minutes, then bake at 375°F for 12–18 minutes until the center reaches 165°F.

Broccoli and cottage cheese frittata

For the variation, add 1 cup cooked chopped broccoli and ½ cup cottage cheese to the frittata mixture. Use a 10-inch skillet and allow a few extra minutes in the oven.

Breakfast scramble with avocado and strawberries

For two people, warm 1 cup turkey base in a skillet. Add 3 beaten eggs and stir gently until set. Serve with ½ sliced avocado and 1 cup strawberries on the side.

Using the same ingredients well

The lettuce wraps, tacos, stuffed peppers and creamy pasta each have an additional produce variation on their recipe pages. Combine the cooked turkey base with cold toppings only when ready to eat.

Taco bowls and sheet pan nachos

October 22 2025

Healthy taco bowls

Serves 3 • 30 minutes

Ingredients. 1 lb lean ground turkey or chicken; 1 tbsp oil; 1 bell pepper; ½ onion; ½ cup corn; ½ cup drained black beans; 1 tomato; 2 cups romaine or spinach; 1½ cups cooked brown rice or quinoa; 1 tsp each chili powder and cumin; ½ tsp each paprika, garlic powder and onion powder; lime; Greek yogurt; avocado, optional.

1. Soften chopped onion and pepper in oil. Add meat and spices and cook to 165°F. Stir in corn and beans until hot.
2. Divide cooked grain and greens among bowls. Add the turkey mixture and chopped tomato. Finish with lime, yogurt and optional avocado.

Variations: use cauliflower rice; replace meat with beans and lentils; add an egg for a breakfast bowl; add mango salsa for a fiesta bowl. Pack hot ingredients and greens separately for meal prep.

Better for you sheet pan nachos

Serves 4 • 25 minutes

Ingredients. 6–8 oz baked tortilla chips; 1 lb ground turkey; 1 tsp taco seasoning; ½ cup each black beans, corn and chopped onion or pepper; ¾ cup sharp cheddar; 1 cup tomatoes; jalapeño; Greek yogurt; guacamole; cilantro; lime.

1. Brown turkey with seasoning to 165°F. Spread chips on a tray; add turkey, beans, corn, onion or pepper, and cheese.
2. Bake at 400°F for 8–10 minutes until cheese melts. Add fresh tomatoes, jalapeño, yogurt, guacamole, cilantro and lime.

Variations: use beans instead of turkey; add cooked eggs for breakfast nachos; use pita, hummus, cucumber, feta and olives for a Mediterranean version; use beans and cashew queso for a vegan version.

Creamy orzo and five variations

January 30 2026

Parmesan thyme and brown butter orzo

Serves 4 as a side • 25 minutes

Ingredients. 1 cup dry orzo; 2 cups warm chicken or vegetable stock, plus more if needed; ½ cup heavy cream; 1 shallot, minced; 2 tbsp butter, divided; 1 tsp olive oil; ⅓ cup Parmesan; 1 tsp thyme; salt and pepper.

1. Soften shallot in oil and 1 tbsp butter. Add orzo and stir for 1 minute. Add stock and simmer, stirring often, for 8–10 minutes or until tender. Add water or stock if the pan dries out.
2. Stir in cream, Parmesan and thyme. Brown the remaining butter in a separate pan and fold into the orzo. Season and serve loose and spoonable.

Wild mushroom and Marsala

Brown 8 oz sliced mushrooms in 1 tbsp butter. Add ¼ cup Marsala and reduce almost dry. Fold into the finished orzo with thyme.

Lemon Parmesan and brown butter

Add 1 tsp lemon zest and 1 tbsp chopped chives or parsley at the end. Adjust with a small squeeze of lemon.

Pancetta shallot and English pea

Crisp 3 oz diced pancetta before adding the shallot. Stir in ¾ cup peas for the final 3 minutes. Optional asparagus can cook with the peas.

Truffle butter

Replace the finishing tablespoon of brown butter with truffle butter. Add it off the heat so its aroma stays distinct.

Herb and ricotta

Fold in ⅓ cup ricotta with 2 tbsp chopped parsley, basil or chives. Loosen with hot stock and finish with lemon zest.

Potatoes for the menus

Four side dishes

Truffle Parmesan smashed potatoes

Serves 4 • 50 minutes

Ingredients. 1½ lb baby potatoes; 2 tbsp olive oil; ½ cup Parmesan; 1 tbsp truffle butter; salt; parsley.

1. Boil potatoes until tender, 15–20 minutes. Drain, steam-dry and flatten on an oiled tray. Brush with remaining oil and roast at 450°F for 25–30 minutes.
2. Add Parmesan for the last 5 minutes. Finish with melted truffle butter, salt and parsley. For fries, use 1 lb cooked fries and toss with Parmesan and truffle butter while hot.

Crispy baby potatoes with pancetta option

Serves 4 • 45 minutes

Ingredients. 1½ lb baby or fingerling potatoes; 2 tbsp oil; ½ tsp salt; pepper; 1 tsp rosemary; 3 oz diced pancetta, optional.

1. Halve potatoes and parboil for 8–10 minutes. Drain and steam-dry, then toss with oil and seasonings. Roast at 425°F for 25–30 minutes, turning once.
2. For the branzino menu, crisp pancetta separately and toss through the potatoes at the end.

Roasted garlic mashed potatoes

Serves 4 • 50 minutes

Ingredients. 2 lb Yukon Gold potatoes; 1 garlic head; 1 tsp oil; 4 tbsp butter; ½–¾ cup warm milk; salt.

1. Cut the top from the garlic, drizzle with oil, wrap in foil and roast at 400°F for 40 minutes. Peel and cube potatoes; simmer until tender, about 20 minutes.
2. Drain and rice potatoes. Squeeze in roasted garlic, fold in butter and enough milk for a smooth mash, and season.

Vegetable sides and salads

June 2025 through September 2026

Candy beet and radish salad

Serves 4 • 20 minutes

Ingredients. 3 small candy cane beets, peeled; 4 radishes; 2 tbsp olive oil; 1 tbsp lemon or orange juice; 1 tsp honey; salt and pepper. Optional: ¼ red onion, 2 tbsp mint or parsley, 2 oz goat cheese and ¼ cup nuts.

1. Shave beets and radishes thinly. Whisk oil, citrus, honey and seasoning, then toss with vegetables. Add optional toppings just before serving.
2. For a softer salad, roast thin beet wedges with a little oil at 400°F for 20–30 minutes until tender; cool before dressing.

Honey roasted multicolor carrots

Serves 4 • 35 minutes

Ingredients. 1½ lb carrots; 2 tbsp olive oil; 1 tbsp honey; 2–3 garlic cloves; 1 tsp fresh thyme; salt and pepper.

1. Heat oven to 425°F. Halve thick carrots lengthwise. Toss with oil, honey, crushed garlic, thyme and seasoning. Roast 20–30 minutes, turning halfway, until browned and tender.

Roasted fennel and asparagus

For four servings, cut 2 fennel bulbs into wedges and toss with 1 tbsp oil, salt and pepper. Roast at 425°F for 25–30 minutes. Add 1 lb trimmed asparagus tossed with 1 tbsp oil for the final 10–12 minutes. Finish with lemon. For plain grilled asparagus, grill oiled spears over medium-high heat for 5–8 minutes.

Shaved fennel and arugula salad

For four small portions, toss 1 thinly shaved fennel bulb and 3 cups arugula with 2 tbsp olive oil, 1 tbsp lemon juice, salt and pepper. Finish with ¼ cup shaved Parmesan just before serving.

Summer sides and steakhouse asparagus

July 2025 • April 2026

Bacon herb potato salad

Serves 4 to 6 • 35 minutes

Ingredients. 1½ lb baby potatoes; 4 bacon slices; 2 tbsp olive oil; 1 tbsp Dijon; 1½ tbsp white wine vinegar; 2 tbsp parsley; 1 tbsp chives; 1 small shallot; salt and pepper.

1. Boil potatoes until tender, 15–20 minutes. Drain and halve. Crisp bacon and crumble.
2. Whisk oil, Dijon and vinegar with finely minced shallot. Toss with warm potatoes, bacon and herbs. Season and serve warm or refrigerate promptly.

Street corn casserole

Serves 6 • 40 minutes

Ingredients. 4 cups corn; ½ cup sour cream; ¼ cup mayonnaise; ¾ cup Cotija, divided; 1 jalapeño; 2 scallions; ½ tsp smoked paprika; 1 tbsp lime juice; cilantro.

1. Char corn in a wide skillet, then mix with sour cream, mayonnaise, ½ cup Cotija, minced jalapeño, scallions and paprika.
2. Transfer to a greased 8-inch baking dish. Add remaining cheese and bake at 375°F for 20–25 minutes until hot throughout, 165°F at the center. Finish with lime and cilantro.

Charred asparagus with lemon Caesar dressing

Serves 4 • 20 minutes

Ingredients. 1 lb asparagus; 1 tbsp oil; ¼ cup breadcrumbs. Dressing: 3 tbsp mayo, 1 tbsp lemon juice, 1 tsp Dijon, 1 small grated garlic clove, 2 tbsp Parmesan and ½ tsp Worcestershire sauce.

1. Whisk dressing and thin with a little water. Toast crumbs in a dry pan.
2. Toss asparagus with oil and grill or broil for 5–8 minutes, turning, until tender and charred. Add dressing and crumbs at service.

Three sauces to keep

Chicken Francese March 2026 • Tuna sauce April 2026 • Mushroom sauce January 2026

Chicken Francese sauce without lumps

Makes enough for 4 chicken cutlets • 20 minutes

Ingredients. 2 tbsp olive oil; 2 tbsp butter, plus 2 tbsp to finish; 3 garlic cloves; 2 tbsp flour; ½ cup dry white wine; 1 cup chicken broth; juice of 1 large lemon; salt, pepper and parsley.

1. Melt oil and 2 tbsp butter over medium heat. Soften minced garlic for 30 seconds. Whisk in flour and cook 1 minute.
2. Gradually whisk in wine, then broth and lemon juice. Simmer 5–8 minutes, whisking until smooth. Remove from heat; whisk in finishing butter and parsley. Serve over cooked chicken cutlets.

If lumps appear, whisk vigorously or strain. A splash of warm broth loosens an over-thick sauce. Cook chicken to 165°F.

Jalapeno cilantro tuna sauce

Makes about 1 cup • 10 minutes plus chilling

Ingredients. 1 cup cilantro; 1–2 jalapeños; 1 garlic clove; juice of 1 lime; ⅓ cup oil; 2 tbsp Greek yogurt or mayo; 1 tbsp honey; 1 tbsp rice vinegar; salt.

1. Blend everything until smooth, starting with one seeded jalapeño. Adjust lime, honey and salt. Chill 10–15 minutes. Spoon lightly over cooked tuna, tacos or a tuna bowl.

Variations: blend in ¼ avocado; add ginger or lime zest; use maple syrup; or add a small splash of soy sauce. Raw tuna versions follow the seafood notes.

Cognac mushroom cream sauce

Serves 4 • 25 minutes

Ingredients. 1 tbsp oil; 1 tbsp butter; 8 oz mushrooms; 1 shallot; 1 garlic clove; ¼ cup cognac; ½ cup stock; ½ cup cream; 1 tsp Dijon; thyme.

1. Brown mushrooms in oil and butter. Add minced shallot and garlic. Remove from heat to add cognac, then return and reduce. Add stock and reduce by half. Add cream, Dijon and thyme; simmer until spoon-coating. Season.

Sauces and simple bowls

Supporting recipes from the dinner ideas

Lemon herb beurre blanc

Serves 2 to 4 • 15 minutes

Ingredients. 1 small shallot, minced; ¼ cup dry white wine; 1 tbsp lemon juice; 1 tbsp cream; 6 tbsp cold butter, diced; 1 tbsp parsley or chives; salt.

1. Simmer shallot, wine and lemon until only about 1 tbsp liquid remains. Add cream and lower the heat.
2. Whisk in cold butter a few pieces at a time, keeping the sauce warm but below a simmer. Strain if desired, add herbs and salt, and serve immediately with branzino.

Chicken and vegetable grain bowls

For two meals, roast 12 oz chicken pieces and 3 cups vegetables with 1 tbsp oil and seasoning at 425°F until the chicken reaches 165°F. Serve over 1½ cups cooked rice or quinoa with lemon and a spoonful of yogurt.

Bean and vegetable pasta

For two to three portions, cook 8 oz pasta. Sauté 2 cups chopped vegetables in 1 tbsp olive oil, add 1 can drained beans and 1 cup tomato sauce, then simmer 10 minutes. Toss with pasta and loosen with cooking water.

Oats and fruit breakfast bowl or smoothie

For one bowl, cook ½ cup oats in 1 cup milk or water; top with ½ cup fruit and ½ cup yogurt. For a smoothie, blend ¼ cup oats, ¾ cup milk, ½ cup yogurt and 1 cup frozen fruit.

Eel and uni hand roll

For four small hand rolls, use 2 nori sheets cut in half, 1 cup cooked seasoned sushi rice, 4 oz fully cooked eel and 2 oz uni intended for raw service. Warm eel as directed. Add a little rice, eel and uni to each piece of nori, roll and eat immediately. Keep sauce minimal and follow the raw seafood guidance.

Stuffies and small plates

Jorts and Forks autumn menu • October 2025

Rhode Island style stuffed clams

Makes 8 small stuffed shells • About 45 minutes

Ingredients. 8 large clean food-safe clam shells or 4 small ramekins; 1 cup drained cooked chopped clams; 3 oz chorizo, diced; 1 tbsp butter; ½ onion, minced; 1 celery stalk, minced; 1 garlic clove; 1 cup breadcrumbs; ¼–½ cup clam juice; 2 tbsp parsley; 1 tsp lemon zest; lemon wedges.

1. Heat oven to 375°F. Cook chorizo in a skillet until its fat renders and it is fully cooked. Add butter, onion and celery; soften for 5 minutes. Add garlic for 30 seconds.
2. Stir in clams, breadcrumbs, parsley and zest. Add enough clam juice to make a moist stuffing that holds together. Taste before salting.
3. Pack into prepared shells or ramekins. Bake for 18–25 minutes until golden and 165°F in the center. Serve with lemon and a little melted butter if desired.

Using cooked clam meat and ramekins keeps the home version straightforward. Bake close to service; the stuffing can be assembled and refrigerated the day before.

A small portion works best

These are rich appetizers. Serve one stuffed shell before the wagyu main, or pair with crostini and a salad for a lighter meal.

Om Ali

October 28 2025 • Warm pastry pudding

Serves 6 • 20 minutes prep • 25 minutes baking

Ingredients. 1 puff pastry sheet, about 8–9 oz; butter for the dish; 2 cups whole milk; 1 cup heavy cream; ½ cup sugar; 1 tsp vanilla; ½ tsp cinnamon, optional; ½ cup chopped pistachios, almonds or hazelnuts; ¼ cup raisins; ¼ cup shredded coconut.

1. Bake puff pastry according to its package until fully puffed and golden, usually about 15–20 minutes at 400°F. Cool slightly and break into large flakes.
2. Reduce oven to 375°F. Butter an 8-inch baking dish. Layer pastry flakes with nuts, raisins and coconut.
3. Heat milk, cream, sugar, vanilla and optional cinnamon just until steaming and the sugar dissolves. Pour evenly over the pastry. Let stand 5 minutes so the liquid soaks in.
4. Bake for 20–25 minutes until bubbling and golden on top. If needed, broil briefly at the end, watching carefully.
5. Rest for 10 minutes and spoon into bowls. Serve warm; the interior should remain soft beneath the crisp top.

Prep ahead: toast the pastry and measure the dry toppings the day before. Keep them dry and separate from the dairy until ready to bake. Refrigerate leftovers promptly and reheat thoroughly.

Espresso martini creme brulee

Jorts and Forks • October 2025

Makes four 4 oz ramekins • 20 minutes prep • 30–40 minutes baking • 4 hours chilling

Ingredients. 1¼ cups heavy cream; ¼ cup strong espresso, cooled; 4 large egg yolks; ¼ cup granulated sugar, plus 4 tsp for brûlée; 1 tsp vanilla; 1 tbsp vodka; a pinch of salt.

1. Heat oven to 300°F. Put four shallow 4 oz ramekins in a deep roasting pan. Heat cream until steaming, then take off the heat.
2. Whisk yolks, sugar and salt just until smooth. Slowly whisk in warm cream. Stir in espresso, vanilla and vodka, then strain into a jug.
3. Divide among ramekins. Pour hot water into the roasting pan until halfway up their sides. Bake 30–40 minutes until the edges set and the centers wobble slightly; the custard should reach about 170°F without bubbling.
4. Lift ramekins from the water bath, cool briefly and refrigerate for at least 4 hours or overnight.
5. Just before serving, sprinkle 1 tsp sugar evenly over each custard. Caramelize with a kitchen torch, moving constantly. Let the crust harden for 1–2 minutes.

The vodka adds the cocktail note but does not make this alcohol-free. The custards can be made a day ahead; caramelize the sugar only at service.

Fruit desserts and birthday ice cream

The dessert pages from the menus

Honeyed figs with mascarpone

Serves 2 • 15 minutes

Ingredients. 4 figs, halved; 1 tsp butter; 1 tbsp honey; $\frac{1}{3}$ cup mascarpone; 1 tbsp cream; 2 tbsp pistachios; flaky salt; a few drops olive oil.

1. Sear figs cut-side down in butter for 2 minutes. Add half the honey and warm through.
2. Whisk mascarpone with cream and remaining honey. Spoon into bowls, add figs and pistachios, and finish with a few drops of olive oil and salt.

Midnight Snack strawberry shortcake sundaes

Serves 4 • 20 minutes

Ingredients. 1 lb strawberries; 1 tbsp honey; $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp lemon zest; 4 slices pound cake or 8 shortbread cookies; 1 pint vanilla ice cream; whipped cream or mascarpone.

1. Slice berries and toss with honey and zest. Let stand 15 minutes.
2. Layer cake or crumbled cookies with ice cream, berries and cream. For a mascarpone version, beat $\frac{1}{2}$ cup mascarpone with $\frac{1}{4}$ cup cream and 1 tbsp powdered sugar.

Kelli mint chocolate birthday bowls

Serves 2 • 10 minutes

Ingredients. 2–4 scoops mint chocolate chip ice cream; $\frac{1}{2}$ cup brownie chunks; $\frac{1}{4}$ cup ready-to-eat cookie dough bites.

1. Chill two serving bowls. Add ice cream, then brownie chunks and cookie dough bites. Serve immediately.

Use cookie dough specifically labeled safe to eat raw. Pre-bake brownies and cut them a day ahead; keep the ice cream frozen until dessert.

Grilled peaches and bourbon caramel

Summer dinner plan • July 2025

Serves 4 • About 30 minutes

Ingredients. 2 ripe but firm peaches, halved; 1 tsp neutral oil; 4 slices pound cake; 1 tbsp butter; vanilla ice cream or whipped cream. Caramel: ½ cup sugar; 2 tbsp water; ¼ cup warm heavy cream; 1 tbsp butter; 1 tbsp bourbon; pinch salt.

1. For caramel, combine sugar and water in a small saucepan. Cook over medium heat without stirring until amber, swirling the pan gently as needed.
2. Remove from the heat. Carefully whisk in warm cream a little at a time; it will bubble vigorously. Add butter, bourbon and salt. Return to low heat briefly if needed to smooth it out.
3. Brush peaches with oil and grill cut-side down over medium-high heat for 3–4 minutes until marked and softened. Cut into wedges.
4. Lightly butter pound cake and toast it in a skillet for 1–2 minutes per side.
5. Put a cake slice on each plate, add peaches and a scoop of ice cream or cream, then drizzle with caramel.

Prep ahead: make the caramel a day ahead and refrigerate. Reheat gently with a splash of cream. Bourbon can be omitted; the sauce will still be caramel.

Drinks from the menus

Dirty martini • Blue cheese olives • Mudslide

The dirty martini

Makes 1 • 5 minutes

Ingredients. 2½ oz vodka or gin; ½ oz olive brine; ¼ oz dry vermouth; ice; 3 green olives or blue-cheese-stuffed olives.

1. Chill a coupe or martini glass. Fill a mixing glass with ice and add vodka or gin, brine and vermouth.
2. Stir for about 30 seconds, then strain into the chilled glass. Garnish with 3 olives. For a frosty finish, shake for 15–20 seconds instead.

Brine guide: ¼ oz for lightly dirty, ½ oz balanced, or ¾–1 oz extra dirty. Taste the brine first; brands vary in saltiness.

Blue cheese olives

Makes 12 • 10 minutes

Ingredients. 12 large pitted green olives; 1 oz blue cheese; 1 tsp cream cheese, optional.

1. Pat olives dry. Mash blue cheese with optional cream cheese to soften. Press a small amount into each olive and refrigerate until serving.

Mudslide

Makes 1 • 5 minutes

Ingredients. 1 oz vodka; 1 oz coffee liqueur; 1 oz Irish cream; 1 oz heavy cream; ice; whipped cream and chocolate syrup, optional.

1. Shake vodka, coffee liqueur, Irish cream and cream with ice for 15 seconds. Strain over fresh ice.
2. For the menu presentation, drizzle the glass with a little chocolate syrup and finish with whipped cream.

Wine on the menus

Kelli's birthday menu lists Sauvignon Blanc. The fig and branzino discussion paired the meal with Vermentino di Gallura. Serve either chilled alongside the food.

Prep ahead for Kelli birthday dinner

A practical service plan for the final menu

Two days before

Bake and press the potato pavé. Cook the tart onions. Make the au poivre sauce base and refrigerate. Bake brownies or prepare the dessert toppings. Check serving dishes, ice, caviar utensils and glasses.

The day before

Cook and chill the sushi rice in its pan. Make spicy aioli and blue cheese olives. Toast sesame seeds. Wash and trim vegetables. If preparing lobster ahead, cook, cool promptly and refrigerate separately from the rolls. Keep seafood cold and follow its package dates.

Earlier on the day

Cut potato pavé and rice into serving pieces. Set out pans, racks, small bowls and platters. Portion butter, cream and sauce ingredients. Keep caviar, lobster and tuna refrigerated. Slice avocado and otoro close to serving.

About an hour before arrival

Bake the fig tart. Roast fennel, adding asparagus near the end. Warm the sauce gently. Prepare the caviar accompaniments and toast sourdough close to service. Set the caviar bowl over ice only when ready to put it out.

When ready to eat

Serve the caviar spread and a small tart piece first. Fry the rice and pavé, then assemble otoro bites. Butter-toast the brioche and finish the lobster rolls. Cook the steaks after the appetizer course so they can rest while the sauce and vegetables finish.

For dessert

Scoop mint chocolate chip ice cream into chilled bowls and add brownie chunks and ready-to-eat cookie dough. This course needs only a few minutes.

Portion guide for two

For the complete menu, aim for 2 small tart pieces, 4–6 otoro bites, 4–6 pavé bites, 2 mini lobster rolls, 30 g caviar, two modest steaks and a shared portion of each vegetable. Save extra components separately.

Cooking and storage notes

Use these notes throughout the collection

Measures and timing

Measurements use US cups and spoons. One tablespoon is 3 teaspoons; 1 cup is 16 tablespoons. Oven temperatures are Fahrenheit and refer to a conventional oven. Times are estimates; thickness, cookware and your oven affect the result. Read each recipe before starting, especially those with overnight chilling.

Checking doneness

Use a food thermometer in the thickest part. FoodSafety.gov lists 145°F with a 3-minute rest for whole beef steaks; 160°F for ground beef and venison; 165°F for poultry, including turkey and duck; 145°F for fish; 160°F for egg dishes; and 165°F for casseroles and reheated leftovers. These temperatures take priority over approximate times.

Raw seafood

Crudo, tartare, otoro and uni involve raw seafood. Ask a reputable seafood supplier about suitability for raw service and required parasite controls; a label alone is not a guarantee. Keep the fish cold, prevent cross-contamination and prepare it close to serving. Freezing does not eliminate every harmful germ. Cooking seafood thoroughly is the safer choice; people who are pregnant, older, immunocompromised or young children should avoid raw or undercooked seafood.

Cooling and serving

Refrigerate perishable food within 2 hours, or 1 hour above 90°F. Cool cooked rice, sauces and fillings promptly in shallow containers. Keep the refrigerator at 40°F or below. Most cooked leftovers keep 3–4 days; freeze portions you will not use. Follow more restrictive seafood, caviar and package directions.

Kitchen details

Take pans off the burner before adding spirits. Use a hand guard with a mandoline. Use only food-grade edible gold and ready-to-eat cookie dough. Keep raw meat preparation separate from foods served uncooked.

Food handling references

FoodSafety.gov — Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart

<https://www.foodsafety.gov/food-safety-charts/safe-minimum-internal-temperatures>

FDA — Selecting and Serving Fresh and Frozen Seafood Safely

<https://www.fda.gov/food/buy-store-serve-safe-food/selecting-and-serving-fresh-and-frozen-seafood-safely>

USDA — Leftovers and Food Safety

<https://www.fsis.usda.gov/food-safety/safe-food-handling-and-preparation/food-safety-basics/leftovers-and-food-safety>

Recipe and menu origins

Conversation dates and menu records

2025

March 28: ground turkey, mushrooms and leeks, including the basic, elevated and additional-ingredient variations.

June 30: candy beet and radish salad, rainbow carrots and truffle burrata.

July 17: the summer dinner plan with tomato ricotta, savory tart, steak, potato salad and peaches.

October 22: Jorts and Forks autumn menu, nachos, taco bowls and simple meal bowls.

October 28: Om Ali.

November 4: Korean barbecue duck, butternut squash, raclette potatoes and banchan.

December 28: Drake Maye steak naming ideas.

2026

January 5: caviar tasting dishes. January 27–30: cognac mushroom sauce, cheese soufflé, venison dinner and orzo.

March 25–27: chicken Francese sauce and flour troubleshooting.

April 16: soft-shell crab and tomato confit; eel and uni pairing. April 24–25: spring Jorts and Forks menu and jalapeño cilantro sauce.

August 11–17: birthday menu development, fig duck sauce, salmon crudo and fondue.

September 2–3: venison noodles, fig leaves, branzino and the fig and tomato menu.

September 15: glazed salmon and the additional Trader Joe's dinners.

September 17–21: dirty martini steak frites, lobster bisque, caviar bites and the dirty martini.

September 21–25: Kelli's birthday menu and preparation plan.

Final menu records

Elegant 31st Birthday Dinner Menu — August 17 2026.

Elegant Blue and Gold Birthday Menu — September 25 2026.

August 11 menu notes preserve the early steak frites, crudo and tuna tartare concepts.

Earlier ideas carried forward

The collection keeps the grilled peach and burrata starter, fondue variations, the tomato-only tart, and the earlier caviar appetizers alongside the final menus. Similar turkey ideas share a base recipe so the variations are easy to use.